Sow and Reap

Contents

Descent of Frost 2
Commencement of Winter 5
Light Snow 10
Winter Solstice 14
Severe Cold 18
Commencement of Spring 22
Rain Water 26
Waking of Insects 28

Descent of Frost

COL-311001

Things are neither entirely "this" nor entirely "that."
By knowing yourself, you see them all.

All things, regardless of creation or destruction, ultimately return to unity.

Grandfather: *A persimmon tree that's meant to bear fruit will bear fruit sooner or later.*

Grandfather: *The frost falls in autumn, the fields of grain wither, and the sweet potatoes rot.*

Grandfather: *But when it's time for it to bear fruit, it will bear fruit.*

Liang Yue's Father: *Get up.*

Liang Yue's Father: *I'm going to start counting now.*

Liang Yue's Father: *Three peanuts.*

Liang Yue's Father: *Two peanuts.*

Liang Yue's Father: *One peanut.*

Liang Yue: **panting**

Liang Yue: *Before its matchless might ... *cough* all evil bends ...!*

Liang Yue: *Ow, that hurts. Father ...*

Liang Yue's Father: *Perhaps this is our true destiny.*

Liang Yue: *What?*

Liang Yue's Father: *You are no longer the master of Qiángliáng.*

Liang Yue: *...?!*

Liang Yue's Father: *It no longer recognizes you.*

Grandfather: *The withering of grass and trees, the retreat of hibernating insects—all these are the natural cycles of heaven and earth.*

Grandfather: *Only after you've truly experienced it all, hearing the faint sound of that which you seek drifting away in vain, will you understand—*

Grandfather: *All things are one with me.*

Chameleon Comms: ... causing structural collapse.

Chameleon Comms: 20-A-11, Code 2, 302 Magdalena Avenue, suspected arcanum-related violent incident causing structural collapse.

Chameleon Comms: Repeat: Code 2, 302 Magdalena Avenue.

Chameleon Comms: What's the situation, Liáng? Are you listening?

Liang Yue: 20-A-11, responding.

Liang Yue: I'm ready.

Part 1 Descent of Frost

Poitier: We figured at first that this could all be caused by drainage issues. After all the rain we got this year, it wouldn't surprise me.

Poitier: And when we got here, everything was underwater, except for their rubber duck.

Two officers walk through the rubble, passing the dazed but alive victims, stopping by a beech tree that has snapped in two.

Liang Yue: On the bright side, it's great for the flowers.

Poitier: Hah, nice try, cadet. I see you've been improving that busted sense of humor. Still a long ways to go.

Poitier: Anyway, during the initial investigation, they found this.

Poitier holds up a clear plastic bag containing a crescent-shaped, crystal-clear hard object.

Poitier: This here is why we got dragged back from vacation. Apparently, it's something only the two finest ladies of the Division of Arcane Affairs can handle.

Liang Yue: Is it a critter claw?

Poitier: Beats me. But we've gotta explore every possibility.

Liang Yue: I'll take a closer look.

Poitier: Yo, wait up!

Poitier: *cough*

Poitier: Apparently, this place is old, like real old, "their grandma's grandma built it with her own two hands" kind of place.

Poitier: Primo location; it's a short drive to the mall and the freeway. Weekend trips up to the estuary.

Poitier: They were putting together a birthday party for their kid right before it started falling.

Liang Yue: A family home like this must be of great significance. I'm certain the loss they feel is immeasurable.

Poitier: Yeah, they're pretty cut-up about it. Everyone made it out okay, though. Thank God.

Poitier: Hopefully, they've got insurance for "Acts of Wanton Arcanum." I'd hate to see them have to tear down this place.

Liang Yue: ...

Liang Yue: Stop.

Poitier: —!

Loose gravel slips from beneath their shoes down into a growing abyss, vanishing without a sound.

Poitier: Holy ...!

Poitier: What in the—that is one big damn hole. We've got our work cut out for us.

Ahead of them, where the house had been, is now an enormous, dark cavity.

Deputy Chief's Office

Liang Yue: We've collected the incident photos and evidence here. The family is safe. We helped them relocate to a nearby motel.

Deputy Chief Elden: Leave it here.

Liáng Yuè salutes the Deputy Chief and prepares to leave.

Deputy Chief Elden: Hold on.

Deputy Chief Elden squints and points to the cabinet beside Liáng Yuè.

Deputy Chief Elden: Let me see that pipe you found. Bring the rest to the evidence lockup.

Liáng Yuè hands him the pipe.

Deputy Chief Elden: Wait, what's that other bag you've got?

She offers him the small bag. Inside lay some sprigs of red ginseng, wrapped in plastic.

Deputy Chief Elden: Oh, I see. "Best wishes and good health to you and your team from the Chinatown School Council," touching ...

Deputy Chief Elden: We can't accept this officially. But, go ahead and take it. I wouldn't even know what to do with ginseng.

Deputy Chief Elden: Have a cup of tea, and go take a break. We can't have our fearless Vigiles cadet collapsing on the job.

Liang Yue: Thank you, Deputy Chief.

Deputy Chief Elden: After that Chinatown case, I don't want you to take on too much too fast.

Deputy Chief Elden: Learning how to recover can be just as important as anything else in this job. Besides, you've got that big test coming up. You need to be at your best.

Deputy Chief Elden: Don't ask me to reschedule it either. It's state-mandated for all officers, including Vigiles.

Deputy Chief Elden: Those results will be a part of your final evaluation for this internship.

Liang Yue: Chief Elden.

Liang Yue: Sorry to disappoint you again, but I really have no idea what you mean. I'm not tired at all. I don't need to recover. I just want to get my work done.

The typically sharp-tongued chief is at a loss for words.

Division of Arcane Affairs, LA

Poitier: I'm still trying to figure out why the chief tolerates all your back-sassing.

Liang Yue: I didn't intend any "sassing," Instructor Poitier.

Poitier: Sure, princess. You know, sometimes I can't wait for you to hit probation and get out of my hair.

Liang Yue: Hard to believe it's almost been six months.

Liang Yue: "Out of your hair," huh? I guess you're right. Whether I pass or not, reassignment seems inevitable.

Poitier: ...

Poitier: Cheer up, kid. I have faith in you.

Liang Yue: Thank you.

Poitier reads her trainee's face, staring her down with probing eyes.

Poitier: Knew it. You're not worried about that exam. You've got something else entirely eating you, don't you?

Liang Yue: No, I am worried about the exam. It's important. It's why I'm here.

The instructor didn't press her trainee, but holds her stare a little longer.

Poitier shakes her head. It's clear she isn't going to break just yet.

Poitier: The Arcane Creatures Lab got back to us with their results.

Poitier: You were on the money, cadet. That crescent-shaped thing we found is from an arcane creature.

Poitier: Not a claw, though. The lab rats think it's some kind of fur, but they're not sure what critter it's from yet. Well, you take a look.

Liáng Yuè takes the offered papers from her partner's hands.

Poitier: I threw in the material analysis from the samples we found under the house too. Just a little treat.

Poitier: Aside from some remains of a few charred critters, they found some kind of superconductive algae.

She pauses for a moment, watching her trainee as she scans the document.

Poitier: Basically, what they're saying is—

She snatches the sample bag from Poitier's hand.

Liang Yue: This material generates high-voltage electrical charges upon contact with air, soil, or water—enough to scorch any critter it encounters.

Liang Yue: So then, that cavern was created by a giant critter burrowing through the ground while producing this substance.

Poitier: ...

Liang Yue: Then this critter might be ...

Poitier: I knew it. So, that's what's been eating you, isn't it?

Poitier: If that legend you told me before is true, then perhaps it isn't gone at all.

Poitier: It was released, and now it's roaming free.

Liang Yue: ...

A sudden gust of wind blows through the open windows of the office, scattering papers into the air.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Hey, shut that window. We're trying to work here.

The window is slammed down, sealing away the gathering wind and storm clouds beyond.

The disheveled cadet stands frozen in place, staring out at the sky.

Liang Yue: Could it really be ...?

Liang Yue: Qiángliáng.

A deep, resonant call echoes from the depths of her memory.

Commencement of Winter

COL-311002

Liang Yue's Father: *Get up.*

Liang Yue's Father: *Get up!*

Liang Yue's Father: *Get ... up ...!*

Motel

Liang Yue: Sorry, please continue. You were saying the appliances stopped working?

The Victim: Yes, it was just like you said. Right before the collapse began, all the appliances started failing one by one.

The Victim: First, the lights went out. Then, the entire house lost power, and everything started trembling. We thought it was an earthquake.

The Victim: Then, everything went completely silent, and the power came back just like that.

The Victim: That's when the house started collapsing. By the time we got outside, we could see the cracks in the earth.

The Victim: There was something under our house, some kind of giant beast. I could really only make out its tail in the darkness.

Liang Yue: Electrical failures ... beastlike appearance ...

Liang Yue: *The witness's statement lines up with what we should expect. Still, we can't rush to assumptions.*

Her pen sputters, leaving blotches of ink on the paper as she records her thoughts.

Poitier: So, what's next? Do we comb through our Arcane Creatures Database for a match?

Liang Yue: No need. I already checked our current evidence against the last ten years of case records. There's been nothing like this in the city before.

Poitier: Holy! The past ten years?! When did you even have time to do all that?

Liang Yue: I thought it might come up, so I took the initiative to check.

Poitier: Hold up! You really went through the whole damn database yourself?

The Victim: Errr, officers, have you figured anything out yet? We just want to put this whole thing behind us before our daughter's birthday.

Liang Yue: I understand. We're doing everything we can to narrow down what caused this. It seems to be an entirely new sort of critter. So, it may take some time to identify the culprit.

Liang Yue: By the way, Poitier.

Liang Yue: I was thinking there is another place that might have information on our "suspect."

Though she maintains her professional decorum in front of the victim, Poitier can read the excitement in her eyes.

City Library

Poitier: The library—I should've figured. But I'm afraid we don't have time to wander around such a big library.

Poitier: Before I let you go bookworm wild, I need to remind you, Elden's got us booked in for the exam today.

Liang Yue: I already took that into consideration. As long as we finish up by 5 PM, there'll still be plenty of time.

Her partner remains unmoved.

Poitier: Sure. You do you, princess.

Poitier: But I'm not sure why we're starting here. This is all just human fiction, oversized fonts, picture books—kiddie stuff.

Poitier: Why not go to the Foundation's archives? You aren't going to find anything here besides Little Lucy Puts on Her Socks and Red Beans and Spam.

Liang Yue: Because I'm looking for exactly that kind of book.

Liang Yue: Look, here it is.

Poitier: Legends of Ancient China?

Poitier: Looks like an ordinary kid's book to me, besides all the Chinese.

Liang Yue: Yes. "Fāngxiàngshì"—that's the name.

Liang Yue: "Qiángliáng expels plagues and drives away evil spirits. It devours all that is ominous and inauspicious." It's a common story about Qiángliáng consuming anything it deems evil.

Liang Yue: And ...

Liang Yue: That's it.

Poitier: That's it?

Liang Yue: ...

Poitier: So, what was the point? That's even less info than what you told me about Qiángliáng the first time.

Liang Yue: Yes, it's more or less the same story I was told as a child.

Poitier responds with a hard stare.

Chameleon Comms: Incident reported at 12 Blue Jacaranda Road. Suspected critter activity resembling yesterday's collapse. Immediate assistance required.

The two leap to attention.

Liang Yue: The time is 4:20 PM now.

Liáng Yuè frowns imperceptibly at the clock.

Poitier: You really wanna take the call? Your exam is in three hours, kiddo.

Liang Yue: ...

Her gaze sharpens, and she hesitates for only a moment.

Liang Yue: The case takes priority.

Part 2 Commencement of Winter

Deputy Chief Elden: So, you two just decided that taking this call was more important than your exam. Have I got that right?

Poitier: Sorry, Chief. The time got away from us. We wanted to follow up to see if this could be the same creature that caused the previous collapse.

Poitier looks over to her trainee. Her mouth opens to continue, but she lets the words trail off.

Deputy Chief Elden: So? Was it?

Poitier flusters at the Deputy Chief's piercing question.

Poitier: The damage was less severe this time—a bit of shaking, some power loss. But we're reasonably certain it's the same creature. Cadet Liáng believes the critter's form is unstable, somewhere between material and ethereal.

Liang Yue: But it got away, sir.

The young cadet lowers her head, mulling over whether to explain her theory.

Liang Yue: It disappeared before we could encounter it.

Deputy Chief Elden: ...

The Deputy Chief's brow deepens, a long silence passing between them in the small office.

Deputy Chief Elden: First, I told you this exam was mandatory and that it cannot be rescheduled. I thought I made myself clear, did I?

Liang Yue: Yes, Chief.

Deputy Chief Elden: Second, I am beginning to see a pattern with the two of you. You think the whole weight of every case has to be on your shoulders. Whether that's hubris or a lack of faith in your fellow officers, I won't tolerate it. Understood?

Liang Yue: Yes, Chief.

Deputy Chief Elden: Is that all you can say? "Yes, Chief"? I thought we already established that I expect more of you.

Deputy Chief Elden: Think it through. Maybe you'll gain a little appreciation for your team after sorting through our archives. You're not going back on duty until you're done.

Deputy Chief Elden: Now, off you go.

Deputy Chief Elden: Don't think I've forgotten about you, Poitier. Letting your trainee miss a mandatory evaluation? Yeah, you can forget about getting that corner desk.

Poitier: Here.

Poitier pokes her trainee with a small cookie.

Poitier: Take it. A bit of sugar will ease the pain of the hiding we just got. Should look familiar—Another gift from our friends in Chinatown School Council.

Poitier: I don't know what you call'em, but they're not half-bad.

Liáng Yuè raises her head up from the desk, hesitating a moment before accepting it into her hand.

The white sugar melts on her tongue, the familiar flavor bringing a touch of comfort.

Liang Yue: They're called Bèngshā.

She sniffles as she takes another bite.

Liang Yue: Kind of reminds me of that first lunch we had.

Poitier: Yeah, back at the diner. Who would have thought we'd end up eating cookies in a dingier place?

Poitier: And staring at a pile of moldy files that even bookworms wouldn't touch.

She picks up a dusty tennis ball nearby, baffling at its random presence.

Liang Yue: I heard from Chief Elden that you wanted to move to the corner desk?

Poitier casually tosses the tennis ball against the wall.

Poitier: He was putting it mildly. It was about my promotion.

Poitier: An Officer Grade III can have a corner desk.

The ball bounces back, and Liáng Yuè barely catches it.

Though they couldn't know it, outside crickets are chirping in the night, and the scent of lotus hangs on the wind.

Poitier: So, what's on your mind, kid? You finally gonna tell me?

Liang Yue: What?

Poitier: You know you're as stubborn as the mules on my granny's farm.

Liang Yue: Pfft ...

Liang Yue: Sorry, I just never imagined you would have grown up on a farm.

Poitier: Why do you think I'm so strong? You don't get a physique like mine without tossing a few hay bales.

Poitier: Now, stop evading my questions.

Poitier: You're acting odd, cadet. Don't try denying it. You know I can read people.

Liang Yue: I was only trying to follow the evidence.

Her voice is clear and resolute.

Liang Yue: I need to know, I have to know—

Liang Yue: Whether this means Qiángliáng isn't really gone.

Liang Yue: After the Chinatown case, I was afraid ... But maybe it was just healing, like it had been the last time it disappeared.

Liang Yue: Maybe it's not gone. It's just hiding, waiting for its wounds to recover.

Poitier: ...

Poitier: I hope you're right. It does fit the profile.

Poitier: The size of the tunnels, the conductive fur samples, the eyewitness accounts—it's a distinct possibility.

Poitier: But that's not what I want to know.

Liang Yue: What?

Poitier: I'm not following—Why do you gotta get Qiángliáng back?

Poitier: You grew up thinking your whole life was going to be about taking care of this ancient beast to continue your "family legacy."

Poitier: But now you don't have to. You can do whatever you want. It doesn't have to be your burden anymore.

Liang Yue: ...

Poitier: You thought I wouldn't figure it out? I know where those mysterious injuries of yours come from. You told me once: "Every blessing has a price." That's the price, ain't it?

Liang Yue: I guess I forget sometimes that you're not just my instructor. You're a skilled investigator, too.

Poitier: Aww, but I can't take all the credit. Elden caught on first.

Poitier: He saw what you looked like after summoning Qiángliáng back in Chinatown. Typical Elden, all he said was "rough."

Poitier: So, I told him I'd keep an eye on you.

Liang Yue: ...

Poitier: Whoever came up with the idea of shaming kids into following their "family legacies" is a goddamn criminal.

Poitier: I'm just worried about you.

Poitier: Because whatever this is, a blessing or a curse, it isn't worth your life. You're so much more than just a vessel for that monster.

Poitier: I know you don't want to disappoint your family.

Poitier: But you're just a kid. You shouldn't have had this put on you. You should've had a choice.

Silence follows her words.

The air feels as thick as glue between them, smelling like a dull mix of old paper and sugar cookies.

Liang Yue: I think you're making a mistake.

Liang Yue: I'm just doing my duty as an officer of the law.

Light Snow

COL-311003

Liang Yue: When I take on a case, I see it through.

Liang Yue: Anything this might have to do with me is ... It's not important. You're just overthinking things.

Poitier: ...

Just like that, the girl slips back behind her mental wall.

Poitier: *sigh*

Poitier: Alright, well, we've got a lot of work left to do before we can get anywhere near our case again.

A knock at the desk window ends their conversation.

Poitier shifts to her feet and opens the window with a saccharine smile.

Poitier: How can I help you today?

Patrolman: Hey, Poitier, I need the file for case number 19770109A-02C. I think it was at the top of that rack last time.

Poitier: Hah, you got it. That's what we're here for.

She whistles sarcastically.

The patrolman glances somewhat blankly at Poitier, then over to Liáng Yuè, as a puzzled look creeps over his face.

Patrolman: Wait, I recognize her. That's our Vigiles cadet, right? Why are you guys stuck in the archives?

Poitier sneaks a smile over at Liáng Yuè before breaking out into a laugh.

Poitier: You're in luck, rookie. You get to behold the consequences of pissing off the Deputy Chief. Listen up, and you might just avoid the same sad fate.

Liang Yue: ...

Patrolman: So, that's why you're stuck sorting files in the archives.

Patrolman: Still, that's really cool.

Patrolman: Sorry. I don't mean ... I just think it's really cool that you have a mythical beast that you can summon as an arcane skill. Like, that power has gotta be unbelievable!

Liang Yue: You think so?

Patrolman: Yeah, but that's gotta be a big responsibility, too, right? Like all that history and tradition gathered together, and it's all on you.

Patrolman: If-If I were you ...

Patrolman: I think it'd be tough.

Patrolman: I don't know if I could ever feel like my own person.

Liang Yue: ...

As the awkward choice of words begins to sour an already overlong conversation, Poitier jumps in with a much-needed rescue.

Poitier: We've got a long night ahead. Let's wrap this up. Here's your file, rookie. Just need a signature and your fingerprint here.

Poitier: Liáng, help me log his file into the system.

Liang Yue: ...

Poitier: You got a problem, cadet?

Liang Yue: Nothing.

Liang Yue: Copy that.

She blinks softly.

???: ...

Silent. Speechless.

The world turns empty.

Liang Yue: ...

Liang Yue: You ...

Liang Yue: Who are you?

Liang Yue: Are you leaving?

Part 3 Light Snow

Poitier: Still awake, cadet? Come on, burning the midnight oil's not so bad, is it? Least this way we get a bit of a break before this place gets busy.

In the narrow hallway, the buzz of radios fills the air. A churning sea of busy officers stop and turn toward the new arrivals.

A few eyes lock on Liáng Yuè before quickly going back to their work.

Chameleon Comms: I repeat, no evidence of an explosion on-site. All residents have been evacuated safely.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Another collapse on Adams Street, Number 13? Copy, we're on our way.

Poitier: See, cadet? Super calm.

There is a silent tension in the office as they make their way to their desks. Eyes dart, and silent, hesitant expressions are shared.

Arcane Affairs Officer I: ...

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Ahem.

Poitier: Great. Why do I feel like a goddamn rookie on her first day again?

An officer stands up and blocks Liáng Yuè's path forward.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Liáng, you led the investigation into the first collapse two days ago, yeah?

Liang Yue: Yes. Why?

Arcane Affairs Officer II: There've been three more incidents in the same area just last night. It's getting worse, too. Five injuries, three in the ICU.

Poitier: Holy ...!

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Everyone's been working around the clock since then.

Liang Yue: Understood. I have some leads. We'll resume our investigation immediately.

The officer rubs his mouth then scratches his head, hesitating to continue.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Actually, uh—

A feigned cough, the words stick in his throat.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: We just have some doubts about your ... objectivity on this case.

Liang Yue: What doubts?

Arcane Affairs Officer II: We need a report of your progress so far, all the details, your leads, so we can collaborate.

Liang Yue: No problem, I'll—

Poitier: Hold on a minute. Don't spit in our faces and call it rain. I know what this is.

She is about to speak, but Poitier cuts her off.

Poitier: First, we're taking our findings to the chief. He can make the call on what to do with it.

Poitier: Cause "collaborate" sounds a hell of a lot more like "take over" to me.

Poitier scans the room, taking in the pricked ears and lowered eyes.

She clears her throat and speaks firmly.

Poitier: Last time I checked, this was still our case. Until that changes, I need a hell of a lot less "doubt" from the rest of you.

Poitier: Besides, what have you got for us? Because unless you have a solid lead like we do, I think you can back off.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: A solid lead?

Arcane Affairs Officer II: How about that based on our evidence, this creature is more than likely to be Cadet Liáng's mythical beast, the Qiángliáng?

Poitier gives her colleagues a meaningful scan.

The knowledge does not seem to be a shock to anyone present.

Poitier: ...!

Liang Yue: ...

Poitier: Didn't think anyone else would figure it out.

Poitier whispers to Liáng Yuè, and halfway through, her eyes widen.

Poitier: Oh—!

Poitier: Never trust a rookie.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: What's your deal, Poitier? We're all on the same team here.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: We all respect Cadet Liáng's abilities, and yours, obviously.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: But with her close connection to this lead, if there's any truth to it ...

Liang Yue: Please don't worry about that.

Poitier: Hey, kid. Don't let them get to you.

Liang Yue: I don't believe Qiángliáng would cause all this destruction.

Liang Yue: Even if, hypothetically, it did—

Deputy Chief Elden: Liáng! My office, now.

Elden's sharp voice cleaves through the room, forcing all eyes back on the cadet.

She stands in the center of it all, chest heaving.

Deputy Chief Elden: This is the third time I've had to haul you in here, cadet. Why don't you just move in here? It'll save me some time!

Elden slams a newspaper on the desk.

"Menacing Mastermind?—Liang Yue and Qiangliang"

Deputy Chief Elden: An anonymous report filed against you.

Deputy Chief Elden: I don't think you need to guess my feelings about this getting into the press.

Deputy Chief Elden: What the hell did you think was going to happen? That we wouldn't find out? That we'd just let you hunt for your lost pet in secret?

Deputy Chief Elden: Now, it's not your fault someone leaked this out. That's someone else's head. But what I can't accept is you two not trusting your fellow officers with this lead.

He pauses for a moment, letting the words sink in, almost daring her to speak.

Deputy Chief Elden: ...

Deputy Chief Elden: I know what this case must mean to you, and why you missed your exam.

His tone softens, becoming almost fatherly.

Liang Yue: Deputy Chief, I need to investigate this case, because I'm the best person.

Deputy Chief Elden: So, you've learned how to grow a spine! Good! But this isn't a test!

Liang Yue: ...

Deputy Chief Elden shifts his stance a little more.

Deputy Chief Elden: You can't trust us with the truth, is that it?

There's a color of disappointment in his voice.

Liang Yue: No, Chief!

Deputy Chief Elden: You thought if you told me, I'd take you off the case.

Liang Yue: No, Chief!

Deputy Chief Elden: That if I knew, I'd doubt your ability, that I wouldn't let you be the one to handle your beast.

Liang Yue: No, Chief!

Liang Yue: My beast ...

Deputy Chief Elden: So, tell me. Why should I? Now that I know you've been keeping the whole division in the dark? How do I know you'll follow my orders and stay objective?

Liang Yue: I will follow my orders.

Deputy Chief Elden: Really? And if you're ordered to imprison this creature? Or destroy it?

Liang Yue: I ...

Liang Yue: I ...

Liang Yue: I ...

Liang Yue: I will follow my orders.

Deputy Chief Elden: Prove it. That last call, Adams Street. I want you there now. If the call is anything to go by, your beast might still be around.

Deputy Chief Elden: We need you.

Liang Yue: Understood.

Winter Solstice

COL-311004

Eyewitness: It was just here! It had this enormous tail, and it tore into the ground, sparks flying everywhere.

Eyewitness: Oh, oh! My god, that's what's causing these tremors, isn't it?

Poitier: Damn it. Stay calm, please. Ugh. The ground's shaking so much I can barely stand.

Poitier: Don't panic. We'll keep you safe.

Liang Yue: Alpha Team, listen up. We need to cordon off everything in a two-mile radius around this scene.

Liang Yue: "It" could surface at any time. Be ready to engage.

Securing her radio, Liáng Yuè vaults over a broken wall, heading toward the epicenter.

Poitier: Liáng—Hey! Liáng!

Liang Yue: This is a .40 USP-series anti-critter handgun, grenades laced with Ceiba soothing pollen.

Liang Yue: Enough to handle this sort of situation.

Poitier: Hey! Liáng! That's the epicenter!

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Poitier, should we follow her?

Poitier: Pfft, only if you're crazy. Stand by and wait for my signal.

Her radio begins to emit strange static sounds.

Phone: Bzz—bzzt—bzzt-bzzt—

Liang Yue: Huh?

Liáng Yuè taps the phone, but it remains unresponsive.

Liang Yue: It's dead.

Deputy Chief Elden: I want you at the intersection of Adams Street and Sycamore. You'll be leading Mobile Unit Alpha. Get there, scout the site, and keep in contact.

Deputy Chief Elden: We'll position three heavy weapons squads at the edges of the cordon to block any escape.

Liang Yue: Heavy weapons?

Deputy Chief Elden: We've seen enough of that creature's destructive power. We can't take any chances.

Liang Yue: Chief, if it's really Qiángliáng, it knows me. It can sense me. I assure you it won't harm us.

Liang Yue: I'll do everything I can to reach it as soon as possible. If I do that, will you allow me to attempt to pacify it?

Deputy Chief Elden: ...

Deputy Chief Elden: Are you willing to take that risk, cadet? You'll be the only one that can get close.

Deputy Chief Elden: Once you're at the epicenter, you'll be on your own.

Liang Yue: Understood, Chief.

Liang Yue: I'll handle it.

Deputy Chief Elden: ...

His silence is long and thoughtful.

Deputy Chief Elden: Alright. Do it. Other officers will be on hand to assist in any way they can.

Deputy Chief Elden: But if that beast puts the public or my officers in danger, I will put it down.

Deputy Chief Elden: Understand me?

Liáng Yuè raises her ink-black irises to meet his, bright and determined.

Liang Yue: I understand.

At the epicenter, the ground beneath Liáng Yuè's feet shakes violently.

Behind her, a growing jam of gridlocked traffic is stuck behind the police cordon.

Driver: Whoa! What is going on, dude?

Poitier: Attention, citizens, we ask that you follow police instructions and detour away from this area immediately.

Driver: Hey, what's happening up there?

Driver: Uh ... huh?

Another strong tremor surges from underground.

Driver: Oh—oh—! Woah! Is this the end of the world? Or did I just have way too much?

Liáng Yuè keeps her eyes fixed on the ground, taking a deep breath.

Liang Yue: Calm down, Liáng Yuè. If it's really Qiángliáng, you'll know it. You can understand it. You can control it.

The ground pulses faster now like a racing heartbeat, heat waves rippling toward her.

Liang Yue: I can feel it. The electrical charge is intensifying.

Liang Yue: I can feel its blood boiling. What an exhilarating feeling. The world is about to burst into steam.

Liang Yue: Yes, it's coming.

She grabs her radio.

Liang Yue: Attention, all squads. This is Liáng Yuè.

Liang Yue: "It" is coming.

The officers at the cordon nearby immediately switched gears, ready for the coming action.

Liang Yue: Three.

Liang Yue: Two.

Liang Yue: One.

A deafening roar erupts as scalding air bursts up from the epicenter.

The column of steam pierces forward like a saw, cleaving open a hole as it moves.

As the air begins to swirl, Liáng Yuè dives to the ground and begins crawling to the edge of the abyss.

Liang Yue: Shhh—shhh—calm down. Calm down. Don't be afraid. We mean no harm.

She calls down into the darkness.

But the creature that lies beneath them does not heed her words.

It strikes the surface again.

Liang Yue: Ah! I can't ...!

Deputy Chief Elden stands ahead of the heavy weapons officers, radio in hand.

Deputy Chief Elden: All units, prepare to fire!!!

Liang Yue: Wait, don't shoot!

Amid the chaos, Liáng Yuè grasps her radio.

Liang Yue: This is Liáng Yuè calling Chief Elden! Liáng Yuè calling Chief Elden!

Deputy Chief Elden: You had your shot, kid.

Liang Yue: But ...!

Deputy Chief Elden: We can't afford to risk the lives of innocent people on another attempt. We can't afford to lose you, either!

Deputy Chief Elden: All units—

From a distance, the precinct's ranking officer raises his hand. Then, with a heavy motion, he brings it down.

Deputy Chief Elden: Fire!

In that moment, her instinct overpowers all sense and reason.

Liang Yue: Wait! Just wait for me!

She leaps into the scorching rush of steam amid a barrage of bullets.

The officers hesitate, letting their heavy guns go silent.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Chief, I think someone just jumped in there!

Poitier: Oh, God, that's ...

Poitier turns back, shouting to Deputy Chief Elden, but he doesn't need to hear her words. He knows.

Deputy Chief Elden raises his right arm almost simultaneously.

Deputy Chief Elden: Hold your fire! All squads, cease fire!

The wind roars.

The candlelight flickers.

The silhouette of the beast dissolves like burnt salt, vanishing into endless emptiness.

Liang Yue: Don't.

A ringing sound ushers in an indescribable vision—the cries of a living being, the world flipping upside down, and the wind sweeping through an old lilac tree in her hometown.

Inside the temple, an ancient bronze incense burner sends smoke rising into the sky. A single goji berry rests atop the burner.

Liang Yue: Ah!

Poitier is the first to leap into the chasm, rushing towards her friend.

Poitier: Damn it, princess! She wants to save it.

Poitier: Liáng!!

Part 4 Winter Solstice

Liang Yue: One jump left, one jump right, jump into Peach Blossom Village.

Liang Yue: One jump forward, one jump back, jump into the reed marshes.

Liang Yue: You jump, I jump, jumping into the warm sun.

Wobbly chalk squares in red and yellow are drawn on a cement floor.

The goji berry perched on the incense burner drips with dew.

It watches silently as the girl plays hopscotch outside the temple.

Liang Yue: A-choo!

The wind rises as if in response.

A faint scent of sorghum wine and the rolling sound of Tang poems drift through the air.

Liang Yue: *cough*

The temple isn't very large, but it is enough to shelter a child unwilling to go home.

The child carefully unwraps a band-aid, aligning it over a wound before patting it gently on her skin.

The candlelight inside casts flickering shadows of the child.

Liang Yue: Hello?! Hello?! This is Detective Liáng Yuè speaking!

It's nothing but an old toy phone. Even if it had been real, she hasn't dialed anyone.

Liang Yue: Don't know who I am? Preposterous! State your name!

There is no answer.

She pauses, as though pondering how to continue her little story.

Liang Yue: Oh, so your name is Qiángliáng? The ancient mythical beast Qiángliáng?

Liang Yue: Alright then. From the sound of your voice, you're probably a weakling and not very scary at all. Why are you calling today?

Liang Yue: You're in trouble, aren't you? You've encountered an even worse "monster." They trapped you in stone, sealed you in a sculpture, left you with nothing to eat, and you're starving every day.

Liang Yue: Unbelievable! Who would do such a terrible thing? Not to worry! Detective Liáng Yuè will bring them to justice!

Liang Yue: No matter how big and bad these monsters bullying little Qiángliáng are, I'll drag them out, slam them down, and beat them up!

Suddenly realizing just how loud her voice had gotten, she stops.

Liang Yue: Sorry I've been doing all the talking. Say something, won't you?

Still, no answer.

But she decides she'll still "listen" attentively, nodding as if someone was tearfully speaking on the other end.

Liang Yue: Of course. Detective Liáng Yuè is the best detective in the world and will protect everyone, including little Qiángliáng.

Liang Yue: If you ever feel lonely, like when you can't find a friend for hopscotch or get scolded by your dad, you can come to me, and I'll help you.

Liang Yue: I won't let you be lonely.

Her voice grows softer and heavier until it falls away.

After a long while, she pretends to end the call.

Liang Yue: Are you real ...?

Liang Yue: Grandfather says you are, Dad too. They talk about you like you're a god, but neither of them has ever seen you.

Liang Yue: ...

Liang Yue: If you were real,

Liang Yue: then you could play with me.

The girl lifts her head from her arms, staring blankly at the flickering candlelight.

Liang Yue: ...

Then, a chant appears softly and dimly at the corner of her mind, drifting in from everywhere and nowhere.

Liang Yue: *Before its matchless might, all evil bends.*

Liang Yue: *Wherever it strides, all terrors end.*

Arise Qiángliáng, swift and fierce!

Banish all evil and cleanse this place.

Her voice is youthful, clear, and pure.

Qiangliang: Huff ... huff ...

The beast before her has eyes like a glowing storm and a broad white-striped forehead. A powerful presence, so vast and near at the same time.

Qiangliang: Huff ... huff ... huff ...

It breathes softly, gazing at her from its bright, clear eyes.

Liang Yue: You-you came? Did you come because I called you?

Liang Yue: Will you be my friend?

She reaches her hand out delicately, moving softly until she touches the beast's nose.

Qiangliang: ...

Liang Yue: Is this your fur?

Liang Yue: It's like lightning. It tickles!

Liang Yue: Can I play with it?

A child hero with an unknown mission rides in from the horizon.

Liang Yue: ...

Liang Yue: ...?

Liang Yue: Uh ...

Poitier: —!

Poitier: Thank God! You're awake!

Liang Yue: What happened to me?

Severe Cold

COL-311005

Arcane Affairs Officer I: Alpha Team is in position. Initial scans suggest no risk of aftershocks. Permission granted to proceed with further support.

Arcane Affairs Officer II: Case ID 2085C39570. Target is now under control. The Transport Team will deliver it to the lab for further analysis.

Liang Yue: So, I saved it?

Poitier: Oh, God, don't make me relive it. You had me worried half to death!

Poitier: Do you have any idea how stupid that was? You dashed in right as they started firing! We all thought you were a goner.

Poitier: Wanna guess what happened? Go ahead. No? Yeah. You got shot, princess.

Liang Yue: What!? Did it get hit as well?

Poitier: Yeah, not that it did any good. Those heavy rounds were meant to subdue massive critters, but they didn't even faze it. All the bullets were dissolved when reaching its skin.

Poitier: I figure only someone as reckless and stupid as you could've subdued it. I still don't know how you managed to get up to its mouth with that sedative.

Poitier: Course, that was when you got hit with a round—BOOM—lights out. Thankfully, it was knocked out too, with you hanging from its neck.

Liang Yue: Is it still alive? Where is it?

Poitier: Whoa, whoa, calm down. You took a big hit, kid. We're not letting you go anywhere just yet.

Poitier's expression is tense and understated.

Poitier: Just be patient. Okay?

She pats her trainee's shoulder with sisterly affection.

Poitier: ...

Poitier: It's alive.

Liang Yue: *sigh* Thank goodness.

Liang Yue: Can I see it?

She starts to jolt up from her hospital bed, only for Poitier to force her back down.

Poitier: What part of "be patient" did you not get, cadet? Besides, I don't think you could stand even if I let you.

Poitier: ...

Liang Yue: ...?

The girl fixes her instructor with a stare and a clear question.

Poitier: ...

Liang Yue: Instructor Poitier?

Poitier: ...

Poitier: Actually, it wasn't even your pal.

Poitier: Yeah. Believe it or not, it was something called a Moshamir Worm, part of the Subterranean Shamirs Genus.

Poitier: The Foundation identified it for us, pretty much as soon as we could get them a picture.

Poitier: A well-documented critter found in the deserts of Asia and Africa. Anyone's guess how it ended up in a grassy SoCal suburb, but we live in a crazy world.

Poitier: They're sending it off for research. The whole "electricity" thing is new. So the eggheads want to do some tests.

Poitier: But what's clear as day is that whatever that thing is, it's not Qiángliáng.

Poitier: Not even the same kind of thing, not even in the same family. Just a worm, a big old creepy-ass electric worm-form critter. So, not your beastie.

Poitier: Qiángliáng, whatever it is, is not something that you could classify as a worm.

It's a creature that defies both classification and comprehension.

As they speak, a breeze slips through the doorway.

And the flowers by her bedside droop.

Liang Yue: ...

Poitier: ...

Poitier: I'm sorry.

A sympathetic hand returns to her shoulder.

Liang Yue: It's not Qiángliáng.

Poitier: No.

A short word and a long pause follow, broken by a deep breath.

Poitier: But I guess we gotta admit ...

Poitier: That Qiángliáng's really gone.

Poitier: For good.

Part 5 Severe Cold

One month later.

Poitier: Congratulations, Officer Liáng! You're finally on your feet again!

Liang Yue: Huh?

A piece of falling confetti lands in Liáng Yuè's open mouth.

Liang Yue: *cough*

Liang Yue: What is all this?

A few colleagues are holding up bouquets of flowers and welcome back cards behind Poitier.

Liang Yue: I thought I was just coming here to collect my dismissal papers.

Poitier: Ah, well, you did mess up—real bad.

Poitier: But that move with the sedative grenade was hard to ignore. You're the reason we caught that thing alive.

Poitier: And once people saw the lengths you were willing to go for Qiángliáng, well, it touched some hearts, I think. They might still think you're a nutcase, but a brave one.

Poitier: I hope you're ready for the Deputy Chief. I don't think he's going to go easy on you this time.

Poitier: If it makes you feel any better, I'll be sure to drop by and visit you in the archives for however long you're stuck down there.

Liang Yue: Hah.

Liáng Yuè drops her head, to hide the faint smile bubbling up on her face.

Liang Yue: Thank you.

Deputy Chief Elden: Get these out of my sight.

At the appearance of the chief, the crowd quickly disperses back to their desks.

Elden strides forward to the two officers, holding a paper bag filled with papers.

Poitier mimes a "just surrender" expression before sneaking off.

Elden is now looming over her like a collapsing wave.

Deputy Chief Elden: Police Law: A+. Criminal Psychology: A. Tactical Operations: A. Mixed Martial Arts: A-. Arcane Knowledge: A+.

Deputy Chief Elden: Do you know which score is missing, cadet?

Elden shakes the assessment sheet in his hand.

When he is at last confident that she's taken in the meaning, he puts it into his back pocket.

Deputy Chief Elden: No promises on a passing grade, after what you put us through with that stunt.

His piercing gaze feels as cold as ice, but it melts against the warm calmness of still water.

Liang Yue: I understand. I'll accept whatever score I'm given.

Liáng Yuè stands at attention, trying not to show a single emotion.

Elden studies her carefully, pausing long enough to draw a bead of sweat from her forehead. Then, he smirks.

Deputy Chief Elden: Listen up. This is just a piece of paper.

Deputy Chief Elden: But it means a hell of a lot more than that once it's submitted.

The ceiling fan creaks overhead, and a green scarab lingers on the dusty windowsill.

Deputy Chief Elden: I've met many kinds of officers in this line of work. Some are glory hounds, some like to spill every little detail to the press, others are no-good crooks.

Deputy Chief Elden: Some are loyal and brave, even when they get chewed up by the system. Some are honest, the kind that will stand up for what's right even against their fellow officers.

Deputy Chief Elden: I've seen too many rookies fall into corruption. No matter what choices they make, they always pay the price.

Deputy Chief Elden: I asked you once, "What kind of officer do you want to be?" That's not the question I want to ask anymore.

Deputy Chief Elden: So let me ask you this, how high a price would you pay to be that perfect officer you want to see in the mirror?

A pause.

The question weighs heavier than any interrogation.

Liang Yue: I—

She nearly steps forward, the answer undeniable in her chest.

Deputy Chief Elden: You don't have to answer me now. Think it through.

He pulls a black pen from his pocket, holding the evaluation sheet in his other hand.

The outcome was decided, written in black and white.

After signing, Elden folds the sheet and tucks it away.

Deputy Chief Elden: You'll get the final results when you're back. The Vigiles will notify you.

The cool breeze carries laughter from the warmly lit precinct.

Liang Yue: *panting*

Liáng Yuè stands in the chilly night air for a long time, staring into the distance.

The scent of hot dogs wafts up from a nearby deli as she looks out toward the distant ocean.

Slowly, she reaches for the waiting phone.

Liang Yue: *Hello, hello? Can you hear me?*

Phone: ...

Liang Yue's Mother: *Hello? Hello! What a surprise. You're calling home today?*

The familiar voice travels across oceans, carried by electric currents.

Liang Yue: ...

Liang Yue's Mother: *Honey, stop reading and come here. Our darling Liáng Yuè is calling!*

Liang Yue's Mother: *I'll put you on speaker, so your dad can hear us too.*

Liang Yue's Mother: *He was just talking about you yesterday, saying he hadn't heard a word since you left.*

Liang Yue: ...

She took a deep breath.

Liang Yue: *My probation period is almost over. I've got most of my results already. Just need to wait for the final outcome.*

Liang Yue: *I'm doing well. The food isn't so bad, and I've met lots of kind people and made many friends.*

Liang Yue: *Every day is fulfilling. The arcane cases here are quite different from those back home.*

From the other end of the receiver comes an eager response, as even the smallest drops of information from her daughter are drunk in deep by her mother.

Liang Yue: ...

Liang Yue: *Mom.*

Liang Yue's Mother: *Hmm? What's wrong?*

Liang Yue: *I lost Qiángliáng.*

A memory surfaces of her childhood visits to the herbal shop with her mother, the air thick with the bitter aroma of medicinal herbs.

Liang Yue's Mother: ...

Fox nuts, poria, angelica, bupleurum—all weighed carefully, gram by gram, dissolving into water.

Liang Yue: *I lost Qiángliáng.*

The ache in her throat connects both past and present.

The bitterness lingers in her nose.

Commencement of Spring

COL-311006

Liang Yue: *It moved, Grandfather! Lift the pole!*

Grandfather: *Oh, that's not a fish biting, just the wind picking up.*

Liang Yue: *Oh, not a fish?*

Grandfather: *The bobber going up and down like that is normal. When a real fish comes, you'll know.*

Liang Yue's Mother: ...

Liang Yue: *That's ... pretty much the situation.*

Liang Yue's Mother: ...

Liang Yue's Mother: *Yuè, your father wants to talk to you.*

Liang Yue: ...

Liang Yue: **exhales**

Liang Yue: *Hi Dad, go ahead.*

Liang Yue's Father: ...

Liang Yue's Father: *You're not hurt, are you?*

Liang Yue: *...!*

Liang Yue: *I-I'm fine. I'm okay.*

Liang Yue's Father: *How far ahead is your rent paid? I need to know so I can book your flight.*

Liang Yue's Father: *Morning arrival or afternoon?*

Liang Yue's Father: *Maybe around mealtime? That way you can have some of your mom's dumplings while they're still warm.*

Liang Yue: ...

Liang Yue: *Dad.*

The receiver in her hand is damp with sweat.

The hallway is silent, save for distant cheers and clattering from the skate park.

Her shadow hangs at the edge of the light, unmoved by the sounds of joy or the creeping stillness of the night.

Liang Yue: *Do you remember the couplet we hung in the hallway before we moved?*

Liang Yue's Father: ...

Liang Yue: *The Han-Wei inscription said: "The paulownia blossoms stretch across the crimson mountain paths, and the young phoenix sings clearer than the old."*

Liang Yue's Father: ...

Liang Yue: *You said it was something meaningful to reflect on. You told me to read it often.*

Liang Yue: *So I read it every day, over and over, until I started to wonder.*

Liang Yue: *What if the paulownia blossoms don't bloom, and the phoenix doesn't sing? Then what?*

...

Questions. Accusations. Anger. Hesitance.

They all fade into silence.

Liáng Yuè hears her father setting down his tea.

The faint clatter suggests his hand had trembled, nearly spilling the cup.

Liang Yue's Father: ...

Liang Yue's Father: *We never told you. That day ... was your grandfather's funeral.*

Liang Yue: *"That day"? You mean ...?*

Liang Yue's Father: *Yes, the day of the Jingzhe festival when you were six.*

Liang Yue's Father: *It was also the day you met Qiángliáng.*

Liáng Yuè raised her hand, studying an old scar.

Liang Yue's Father: *Your grandfather spent his whole life hoping to see Qiángliáng.*

Liang Yue's Father: *His mastery of arcane skills was the strongest in five generations of our family, yet he left this world filled with regret.*

Liang Yue's Father: Even after all I suffered through, from his expectations and his disappointment, I can't find it in myself to hate him.

Liang Yue: ...

Liang Yue's Father: *That couplet. I remember it.*

Liang Yue's Father: *I've packed it away.*

Her father takes a deep breath, the weight of years laced with remorse finally granting an innocent prisoner their exoneration.

Liang Yue's Father: *That rain was never meant to fall on you, yet you bore it all.*

Three chimes from the ancestral bell echo in her head, clearing a lifetime of doubt.

Liang Yue: *Grandfather, the fish still aren't biting.*

Grandfather: *Haha, patience is the key with fishing.*

Grandfather: *Here, take this little stick. You can draw in the dirt while you wait with me.*

Liang Yue: *Draw ... Hmm, what should I draw?*

Grandfather: *Whatever you like. Fish, birds, anything you like.*

Liang Yue: *Something I like, oh, I know!*

Liang Yue: *Grandfather, look!*

Grandfather: *What's this? It's not a tiger or a dragon.*

Liang Yue: *It's my secret friend.*

Grandfather: *A secret friend? Oh! Wait, I see it now. You're drawing Qiángliáng, aren't you?*

Liang Yue: *Yes.*

Grandfather: *Haha, Yuè, that's not a very easy thing to draw.*

Grandfather: *Why don't you try something else? A bunny, a fox, or that stray cat we saw last time?*

Liang Yue: *But I want to draw it.*

Liang Yue: *I just want to draw it.*

Liang Yue: *You said to draw what I like.*

Liang Yue: *And I love it.*

Liang Yue: *—!*

Liang Yue: *I ...*

Liang Yue: *I ... love it?*

Three more chimes from the ancestral bell.

Liang Yue: *I ...*

Liang Yue: *I ...*

Liang Yue: *I ...*

Liang Yue: I ...

Liang Yue: Father ...

Part 6 Commencement of Spring

Liang Yue: "I Love Los Angeles" T-shirts—ten in total. Besides family, one for the neighbor's kid, Huhu, too.

Liang Yue: And Dad's watch, packed. The meat grinder Mom wanted, packed. Fancy cat toys for Mimi, packed.

Poitier: Hey, I'm not interrupting, am I?

Poitier: Has our little hero not finished packing yet? Everyone's ready for your farewell party.

Liang Yue: Did Deputy Chief Elden really let you decorate the precinct like, uh, what did he call it, "a high school prom"?

Poitier: What does he know about dances? That guy definitely was not invited to parties.

Liáng Yuè chuckles, shaking her head.

Poitier: So, heading out the day after tomorrow?

Liang Yue: Yes.

Poitier: Oh, you got plans for the next two days? Studying for the makeup test?

Liáng Yuè thinks to herself, searching for an answer.

Liang Yue: I want to take some time to just enjoy the moment.

Poitier: Hold on a minute. Enjoy the moment?

Liang Yue: Yes.

Poitier: Wow, that's a new one from you.

Liang Yue: I'll probably only hear from the Vigiles about their final decision after I return.

Liang Yue: For now, I just want to try all the things I've never done before or didn't dare to do.

Poitier: Hmmm.

Facing such undeniable conviction, Poitier could only whistle.

Poitier: Don't sweat the results, princess. Between you and me, I overheard Elden talking to the Foundation. It was all good stuff. I think he's got a soft spot for troublemakers.

Liang Yue: Thank you, Instructor Poitier.

Poitier: Ahem! What? What are you thanking me for?! I didn't do a single thing!

Liang Yue: No, you've helped me the most.

Poitier: ...!

Sincerity, at times, can be its own way to stop a conversation.

Fortunately, it also paves the way to deeper connections.

Liang Yue: By the way, Poitier.

Poitier: Yeah, what's on your mind?

Liang Yue: When I get home, I'd really like to send you some local specialties from my hometown. I hope you'll try them!

As if trying to conceal some emotion, the instructor awkwardly twitched her nose.

Poitier: Why certainly, Ms. Liáng.

Rain Water

COL-311007

Liang Yue: Uh, is this the switch?

Liang Yue: Oh, the red light's on. That means it's working.

Liang Yue: Ahem. This is Liáng Yuè.

Liang Yue: I'm currently at the largest amusement park in Los Angeles. Today's weather is sunny.

Liang Yue: And my goal is to conquer all the most thrilling roller coasters and haunted houses.

Liang Yue: Please keep this a secret from my mom and dad.

Liang Yue: This is Liáng Yuè.

Liang Yue: Yes, I'm at the most famous fortune-telling bar in LA. The owner is a renowned arcane magician who, they say, can craft unforgettable drinks just by looking at a customer.

Liang Yue: Next, I'll take a sip and report back.

Liang Yue: This is Liáng Yuè.

Liang Yue: Shh, I have to keep my voice down because I'm attending a solemn, traditional funeral.

Liang Yue: An elder passed away peacefully. I can only hope the same for myself and those around me.

Liang Yue: Hey, this is Liáng Yuè. And now I'm on my flight home.

Liang Yue: Since we didn't really get to know each other very well before, I think sharing a little about our lives is a good idea.

Liang Yue: Though I haven't received a reply yet, I'm looking forward to what's to come.

Liang Yue: Hello? Mom, yes, the flight has been delayed for two hours. I won't be home for dinner. Yes. That's right. I'll be in around two hours later.

Liang Yue: Yes, Flight 243. I didn't mix it up. They always have last-minute delays.

Deputy Chief Elden: *Have a safe trip!*

Deputy Chief Elden: How was that? I've been practicing my Chinese. I think I got it that time.

Liang Yue: Your pronunciation is spot on, sir.

Liang Yue: Though I can't guarantee there isn't a criminal whose arcane skill activates upon hearing a foreign phrase they don't understand.

Deputy Chief Elden: Always a sharp one. Haha, that's the kind of officer I've trained.

Poitier: Liáng, if you earn that Vigiles badge, you let me know right away.

Liang Yue: I will.

She winks at Poitier and then takes one last, lingering look around.

Liang Yue: Everyone ...

Liáng Yuè salutes her colleagues with a fond smile.

Her friends and coworkers rise up and return her salute.

All Officers: *Have a safe trip!*

Liang Yue: We used to come here all the time.

Liang Yue: Turn left here. There used to be a locksmith. Mom said they made a fortune and moved away.

Liang Yue: Things change so fast, Qiángliáng. Even though we've only been gone six months, this little town has changed so much more than I could ever imagine.

Liang Yue: Look, we're back.

Liang Yue: ...

"A god wields a snake, bears a tiger's head and human body, and has four hoofs and long elbows. Its name is Jiangliang."

"Qiangliang and Zuming feed on Zhesi and Jisheng. Qiangliang is synonymous with Jiangliang, as ancient texts show."

Blessed are the steadfast in the face of thunder and adversity, who can chase plague to the ends of the earth and bring peace to all.

Open the way to peace everlasting.

Grandfather: *This is a document written in Bronze Script between the Shang and Zhou dynasties, recording events from ancient times.*

Grandfather: *It's been badly damaged. Restoring it won't be easy.*

Grandfather: It's been out here for a hundred years. But aside from you and me, no one in this family knows it exists.

Grandfather: *You—you're a coincidence. You stumbled upon this book by sheer chance.*

Grandfather: *And I ... I'm the one tasked with rewriting it.*

Grandfather: *It records the ancient ritual that is said to awaken Qiángliáng.*

Grandfather: *It also lists every member of the Liáng family who underwent these trials.*

Grandfather: *Some of them were so drained by the rites that they needed years to recover.*

Grandfather: *Sometimes they never really recover at all.*

Grandfather: *So, let me ask you one last time: Are you sure you want to know what's written inside?*

To burn a single white candle.

Liang Yue: *Spring thunder stirs the insects. Life begins anew.*

From a carved, black-lacquered agarwood chest, she retrieves a ceremonial dress.

Liang Yue: *It's been so long. I can hardly remember the year Qiángliáng appeared.*

She dons the garment.

Liang Yue: Father, Grandfather, I have a different view of things now.

She places the ritual mask over her head.

Liang Yue: I don't think it's a fleeting blessing or curse, nor is the rain that has drenched generations of our family.

Everything is in place.

Liang Yue: It's just itself.

Liang Yue: We've never truly understood what it really is.

She stands in the courtyard, facing the shrine.

Liang Yue: Why it chose me, how it perceives me—these are answers I want to hear from its own mouth.

Liang Yue: I won't wait for it to reach out to me this time.

Liang Yue: I want to embrace it this time.

Step One:
The Tool.

The orioles fall silent. Plants bow to the earth.

Step Two:
The Priest.

The censer's smoke rises. Ancestral spirits shine bright.

Step Three:
The Incantation.

Winds surge in from all directions.

Liang Yue: *Step Four ...*

Liang Yue: Blood ...

Things are neither entirely "this" nor entirely "that." By knowing yourself, you see them all.

Liang Yue: *If you've truly disappeared from this world ...*

Liang Yue: *Will you ever answer my call again?*

Her hands move in strange, ritualistic gestures, reminiscent of Nuó Dance. Sparks of electricity burst forth from her bloodied fingertips.

Thunder roars as silver streaks of lightning slither along the walls, and the heavens seem to bow down to the earth.

Liang Yue: Before its matchless might, all evil bends.

Liang Yue: Wherever it strides, all terrors end.

Liang Yue: Arise Qiángliáng, swift and fierce! Banish all evil and cleanse this place!

Part 7 Rain Water

Waking of Insects

COL-311008

Open the way to peace everlasting.

Liang Yue's Father: *The person who was entrusted with Qiángliáng took Liáng as their surname, passing this knowledge down through their descendants.*

Liang Yue's Father: *But to this day, the Xiǎndào Beast, Qiángliáng, has not appeared to a Liáng family member for nearly a century.*

Liang Yue's Father: *If the mind wavers or selfish desires dominate, Qiángliáng may turn on its master.*

Liang Yue's Father: *You are destined to carry on the Liáng legacy and bring glory to our name!*

Liang Yue's Father: *For the 101st time, wipe off your sweat. It'll affect your vision.*

Liang Yue's Father: *Stand before the ancestors' tablets with steadfast posture and grounded breath!*

Liang Yue's Father: *That opening stance is feeble. Your crouching stance is too clumsy. Your entire form is haphazard and weak!*

Liang Yue's Father: *Stand up! Again! Do it again!*

Liang Yue: Do you hear their voices?

Liang Yue: Morning and night, they come to honor you, to beg blessings from you.

Liang Yue: What they pray for, their countless requests, have nothing to do with you or me.

Liang Yue: Locked away in a statue for so long, you must be lonely.

Liang Yue: Hello?

Liang Yue: Hello?

Liang Yue: Let me know if you can hear me.

Liang Yue: This is Officer Liáng Yuè—

Liang Yue: I'm calling out to you.

The colossal beast before her glares menacingly, hot vapor seething from its jagged fangs.

The red clouds of the night burst like blood blossoms behind it. It looms over her as tall as a pagoda, striking awe and terror.

Its eyes are hot sears that burn into her skin. The tiny figure at its feet is emotionless and inscrutable.

Liang Yue: Don't you recognize me?

The beast scrapes its claws against the ground, lowering into a poised stance.

She recognizes the move. It wasn't friendly. It was preparing to strike.

Liang Yue: I see. Waking you up won't be so simple.

Liang Yue: I'll have to entertain you first, right?

Before she could finish, the beast lunges out like an arrow from a bow.

Stones tumble, and the temple appears on the verge of collapse.

Her pounding heart pushes blood and primal adrenaline through her veins. Liáng Yuè lands barely along the edge of a water tank.

Liang Yue: Huff, huff. You really don't hold back, do you? I didn't think you'd come at me with full force.

Liang Yue: But I knew playing with you would come with some risks.

The beast tilts its head to look around. With a flick of its tail, a row of roof tiles tumbles to the ground.

Liang Yue: Calm down, Liáng Yuè. Even without it, you have your own strength.

Liang Yue: You can defeat it.

The wind howls, carrying bamboo leaves and debris swirling through the air.

In the hazy moonlight, the sweat on the girl's nose glistens with a silver sheen.

Liang Yue: First Move: Starting Form.

Focus your breath in your core, feet skimming the ground, as though lifting a thousand pounds.

Liang Yue: Second Move: The Dance.

The rain and wind serve as blades. Roars become bullhorns. Dance to the rhythm, the wilder, the better.

Liang Yue: Third Move: Pressing the Seal.

Twelve-hour scripts, nine palaces, and eight trigrams. Fingers spin like scattered stars, reshaping the cosmos.

Liang Yue: Fourth Move: The Heavenly Step.

Rise to the heavens, traverse the nine provinces, and roam the world. Starry pearls shine in the cosmos, eclipsing all beauty.

Liang Yue: Fifth Move: Stomping Fire.

Thunder and fire collide. Swarms of cobalt blue damselflies gather and spread, becoming phosphorus flames and burning everything to ash.

Liang Yue: Sixth Move: Banishing Evil.

Flames roll across her skin as the beast unleashes a deafening roar, retreating step by step against the tolling of the copper bells.

Only then can one understand—

All things are one with me.

With a fierce roar, the beast turns the night blood-red. Moonlight shatters like bones, illuminating the girl's flowing black hair in the wind.

Dressed in ceremonial attire, the girl murmurs, her form shifting as she combines martial arts and ritual dance. She harnesses her energy, bamboo leaves spiraling like knives in the air.

Copper bells chime, resonating through the tiled temple. The beast shudders under the relentless clanging, retreating inch by inch.

Qiangliang: Arooo—!!!

Under the vast sky, the beast let out a painful wail.

Liang Yue's Mother: *Did you feel that?*

Liang Yue's Mother: *It felt like an earthquake.*

The rhythmic chopping slows to a stop.

The elderly couple turns to look out the window.

Liang Yue's Father: *Listen closely. That sounded like a tiger's roar.*

Liang Yue's Mother: *The sound is so vivid. It's coming from the temple.*

The two lock eyes, faces shifting into mutual realization.

They have a bad feeling.

Liang Yue's Father: *We need to go.*

Liang Yue's Mother: *Huff ... huff ...*

Liang Yue's Mother: *Yuè—?!*

Liang Yue's Father: *Yuè? What are you doing here? Didn't you say your flight was delayed?*

The temple is tranquil now. Duckweed ripples gently in the cistern.

Despite the bamboo shadows swaying, all traces of the storm have vanished.

There standing in the moonlit courtyard is a girl.

She turns to face them.

Liang Yue: *Father, Mother.*

Liang Yue's Mother: Why are you wearing ceremonial attire?
What were you doing out here?

The question is loaded with meaning. She never doubts her mother's intuition. But now isn't the time.

Liang Yue: *Oh! Nothing, I just came back early and thought I'd surprise you, so I didn't tell you.*

Liang Yue's Mother: *Surprise? Who surprises someone by coming to the temple and making a racket? That's ...*

She looks over to her husband, expecting a matching response.

He says nothing but gives his daughter a long and deep stare, filled with unspoken words.

Then, he reaches out for her.

Liang Yue's Father: *You look full of energy.*

Liang Yue: *That's because I'm your daughter.*

She gently takes her father's hand from her shoulder.

Liang Yue's Father: *Hahahaha!*

Liang Yue's Father: *Come on! Let's go home for dinner.*

Liang Yue: *Wait a second, Father, Mother.*

Liang Yue: *Can I invite a little friend to join us for dinner?*

Liang Yue's Mother: *Of course! Why not?*

Liang Yue's Mother: *Who is it? A new friend you made in America? Or an old classmate from the academy?*

Liáng Yuè shakes her head and takes out her phone, dialing a number.

The beast appears before them.

Liang Yue: *Allow me to introduce you to my new colleague and friend.*

Liang Yue: *Officer Qiángliáng.*

Text Message: "."

Text Message: "--&@ ... #% ..."

Text Message: "..."

Text Message: "..."

Text Message: "(#￥(()#——"

Text Message: "..."

Text Message: "@ ..... @ ..."

Liang Yue: Huh, it seems like deciphering your language will take some time.

Liang Yue: But we can do it, right?

The beast hears her and shakes itself, lifting its chin to give Liáng Yuè a sideways glance.

Then, almost imperceptibly, it nods.

Liang Yue's Mother: *Qiángliáng wasn't really lost, was it?*

Liang Yue's Mother: *But ...*

Liáng Yuè wonders how to explain, but her mother's concern is cut short.

Liang Yue's Father: *Well, losing it wouldn't have been a bad thing, and keeping it isn't something to take for granted either.*

His gaze lingers on his daughter for a moment longer, studying her with doubt until he looks away.

He exhales deeply, releasing a breath that had been stuck in his chest.

Liang Yue's Father: *We're just glad you're alright.*

The coarse hand that had almost settled on her shoulder hesitates and falls to his side.

The family's shadows stretch long as they walk away, their outlines tracing the moss-covered stone steps of the temple.

The stone steps silently crack open.

The fissure runs upward along the pillars, past several beams, reaching the temple's roof ridge, where two Chīwěn statues perched.

Liang Yue: *—!*

She swivels back to look back at the temple.

In the cool night, it seems almost like a mirage, majestic and serene.

Liang Yue's Father: *What's wrong, Yuè?*

Her father follows her eyes backward.

From behind the temple, a flock of white cranes takes flight.

Their snow-white wings stretched wide under the boundless sky before folding back again, soft feathers gently floating down from above.

Liang Yue's Father: *What are you looking at?*

It's a fleeting moment lost in a trance.

Liang Yue: *Nothing.*

She watches the flock of white cranes and smiles before stepping across the temple's threshold.

Part 8	Waking of Insects
Liang Yue	as Herself
Qiangliang	as Itself
Poitier	as Herself
Elden	as Himself
Liang's Father	as Himself
Thank You	For Watching